Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Rudyard Kipling's "Deep Sea Cables"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of imagery's role in emphasizing the theme of communication in Rudyard Kipling's "Deep Sea Cables" include

alliteration,
diction,
imagery,
liminality,
melopoeia [words characterized by musical property(s) that induce emotional correlations through both sound and rhythm],
metaphor,
onomatopoeia,
personification,
reification,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sigmatism,
synæsthesia,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

The young Lit Critter's response should address the melopoeic elements that carry Kipling's theme, which is found, explicitly stated, in the poem's final line: "Let us be one!" The strongest example of the auditory imagery's carrying—literally—the communication endeavor through the advanced technology of undersea networking of the continents is found in the onomatopoeic "flicker and flutter and beat" (line 6), which the student might recognize—the footnote providing the clue—as an auditory representation of Morse Code. Additionally, the diction choices, charged with alliteration, sigmatism, and the visual imagery, e.g., sea snakes (line 2), "deserts of the deep" (line 3), "the great grey level plains of ooze" (line 4), carry a complementary auditory quality that echoes the characteristics of human speech, which might be argued as an emphasizing of that "Power troubl[ing] the Still" that is powerless to respond "neither voice" and react "nor feet" (line 8).

Something might be made of the onomatopoeic quality of the visual and tactile imagery—something toward synæsthesia—e.g., line 1's *dissolve*, line 4's *ooze*, line 10's *gloom*.

The clever analyst might suggest that the inconsistency of the poem's metrical pattern is a perhaps decipherable Morse Code message itself, or she might simply point out that the neither accentual nor accentual-syllabic verse complements the melopoeic qualities of the poem.